

self," recalls a beaming Padalkar.

Not every successful woman has such mentors at work or home. Every woman professional's journey is different, yet each one carries a powerful story. And there are many such stories from the past few decades, especially in the BFSI sector—ICICI Bank's Kalpana Morparia, Renuka Ramnath, and Lalita D. Gupte; HSBC's Naina Lal Kidwai; and RBI deputy governor K. J. Udeshi (the first woman to hold the post) and later Shyamala Gopinath and Usha Thorat. They all began working in the 1970s, when a career was not the norm for women.

Renu Sud Karnad, former MD of HDFC Ltd and now an independent director on boards of several companies, offers a glimpse into those years and what kept her motivated. She started her journey at HDFC, where the mission was to help middle-class families buy a home—something that was very difficult before HDFC came into being in 1977.

"Knowing that our work made a real difference to society kept me driven, and I could see the impact of doing the job well," Karnad says. Her parents and husband supported her fully. "When your focus stays on results, gender slowly stops being the defining factor. It took perseverance, but the belief that good work speaks louder than perceptions helped me stay the course," says Karnad.

The women of her era began their journey despite facing numerous challenges. But something within kept pushing them forward, turning them into inspirations for many young women in subsequent years. That shows in numbers. According to a 2024 CareEdge-ESG analysis of 59 BFSI companies with a combined workforce of 1.89 million employees, including 632,000 women, the median female representation in the sector stands at 22%. Women accounted for 10-30% staff strength at most companies in FY24.

WHAT'S DRIVING THIS

The shift did not happen overnight. "Over the years, the system has become more supportive of women," says Karnad. Without doubt, HR policies around diversity, maternity leave, workplace safety, flexible work, mentorship, equality at work, and workplace harassment have given women more confidence to build a long career.

"I think that the BFSI/fintech sector is perhaps a bit easier for women to thrive in. The conducive environment is a combination of various factors, including employee-friendly policies, relatively younger workforce, increased use of technology, and a culture of inclusive leadership, which attracts more women to the workforce," says Padalkar.

It helps that women can see real role models in fi-

Leading the Change



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nance now. As more women enter the industry, companies have realised that a diverse leadership strengthens teams and improves how businesses connect with customers, says Padalkar.

Karnad believes women today are no longer restricted by geography or hierarchy—digital platforms let them learn, lead, and draw inspiration from those who have broken barriers. This has expanded their horizons, showing them what's possible. "Technology now enables women to showcase their abilities and access opportunities without depending on legacy networks," she says.

Radhika Gupta, MD & CEO of Edelweiss Asset Management, attributes this to the power of the pipeline. "Over the past two decades, many more women entered finance at the entry level, and that cohort is now reaching leadership positions. So, this moment has been building quietly for a long time," says Gupta, who was entrusted with large, complex assignments—like man-